

Reality Drift Framework Provenance Record

Origin, Development, Intellectual Lineage, and Archive

A. Jacobs

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Supersedes separate provenance and framework administration statements.

Purpose

This document establishes the provenance of the Reality Drift framework as a continuous developmental record. It identifies the framework's originating inquiry, development, intellectual lineage, and archival structure. It also distinguishes the framework's original synthesis from the prior traditions that informed it.

Reality Drift emerged from A. Jacobs's sustained inquiry into a recurring structural condition in which systems remain operational and internally coherent while losing corrective contact with the realities they were built to represent, regulate, or serve. Books, essays, notes, visual systems, public repositories, concept papers, and retained developmental materials document the movement from early intuition to a more stable framework.

Origin and Contribution

Reality Drift is a framework developed by A. Jacobs for describing how systems can remain operational and internally coherent while losing corrective contact with the conditions they represent or serve.

The framework is not presented as the discovery of every mechanism it contains. Proxy failure, feedback degradation, abstraction, recursive systems, semantic loss, institutional self-reference, mediated perception, and related problems have substantial prior literatures. The contribution lies in bringing these mechanisms into a common architecture centered on persistent functionality after corrective contact has weakened.

The framework also connects institutional, semantic, cognitive, technological, and cultural forms of drift without treating their surface differences as identical. Its development involved identifying recurring structures across domains, forming a vocabulary around those structures, and progressively narrowing the framework's boundaries and claims.

Canonical Definition

Reality Drift is the condition in which a system preserves operational coherence while progressively losing fidelity to the reality it was created to represent, respond to, regulate, or serve. Drift becomes

possible when representations grow easier to optimize and circulate than the underlying reality is to consult, and when correction weakens enough for misalignment to remain survivable.

The framework's durable distinction is between coherence and contact. A system may remain organized, productive, fluent, measurable, or institutionally legitimate without remaining aligned. Visible breakdown is therefore not required.

The absence of failure is not proof of alignment.

Developmental Record

The dates below describe phases of formation rather than isolated moments of invention. Reality Drift developed through accumulation, comparison, naming, revision, and compression. The archive preserves that sequence rather than presenting the framework as if it appeared fully formed.

2022 to early 2024

Private notebooks, structural notes, fragmented essays, and adjacent writing explored representation, perception, institutional logic, mediation, and lived unreality.

What this period established: The pre-framework inquiry and the earliest identifiable intuition that systems can remain operational while becoming misaligned.

Mid 2024

Comparative work across algorithmic media, institutions, information overload, semantic systems, and artificial intelligence began isolating compression, proxy substitution, representational layering, and degraded feedback.

What this period established: The transition from diffuse observations to recurring mechanisms.

Mid 2025

Essays, briefs, Substack work, independent publications, and repository deposits began consolidating the inquiry into a public research archive.

What this period established: The first broad public legibility of the developing framework.

Late 2025

Reality Drift stabilized as the central term. Synthetic Realness, Filter Fatigue, and Optimization Trap became related constructs. Visual explainers and maps were used to test the architecture.

What this period established: Naming, differentiation, and public circulation of the conceptual system.

December 2025

The Age of Drift consolidated earlier notes, fragments, and working intuitions in book form.

What this period established: A major developmental state before the canonical distinctions had fully stabilized.

2026

Canonical papers clarified definitions, mechanisms, boundaries, Semantic Fidelity, Recursive Compression, constraint, cognition, and applications across institutions and artificial intelligence.

What this period established: The framework's mature internal architecture and its rules for current authority.

September 2026

The framework was refreshed and consolidated into a quieter canonical archive, with this provenance record replacing scattered administrative statements.

What this period established: A single reference point for origin, development, authorship, AI use, lineage, and archival precedence.

Development Method

The framework developed through repeated comparison across institutions, media, artificial intelligence, cognition, and other domains. Writing, visual mapping, and dialogue were used to test whether recurring patterns held across different contexts. Concepts were expanded, compared, revised, renamed, combined, or discarded as the framework developed.

Over time, this process reduced a broad field of observations into a smaller vocabulary of recurring mechanisms and distinctions. The resulting concepts include Reality Drift, the Drift Principle, Semantic Fidelity, Constraint Collapse, Recursive Compression, Synthetic Realness, Filter Fatigue, Optimization Trap, Cognitive Drift, Temporal Drift, Drifted Self, and Co-Cognition.

Earlier materials preserve the movement and experimentation that produced these concepts. Later canonical documents preserve their more stable definitions and relationships.

Intellectual Lineage and Original Synthesis

Reality Drift belongs to a recognizable intellectual lineage. The framework draws on prior accounts of abstraction, feedback, information, media environments, institutional self-reference, embeddedness, mediation, cognition, and symbolic systems. It does not claim these traditions as inventions of the project. It reorganizes their shared structural concerns around a more specific problem: how systems can continue functioning after their relationship to underlying reality has weakened.

Alfred Korzybski

Korzybski's work on abstraction and the distinction between maps and territory informs the framework's treatment of representational layering and the risks of treating symbolic maps as substitutes for underlying conditions.

Gregory Bateson

Bateson's work on recursive systems, ecological relation, information, and feedback informs the framework's emphasis on relationships, correction, and the consequences of weakened feedback.

Norbert Wiener

Wiener's work on cybernetics, control, communication, and signal integrity informs the treatment of feedback degradation and systemic adaptation.

Claude Shannon

Shannon's work on information, transmission, and compression provides part of the background for thinking about what may be preserved or lost as representations are transformed.

Terrence Deacon

Deacon's work on emergence, constraint, symbolic systems, and absence informs the framework's treatment of meaning as dependent on relationships and constraints rather than isolated information alone.

Marshall McLuhan

McLuhan's treatment of media as environments that reorganize perception and social form informs the analysis of mediated environments that alter contact with underlying conditions.

Niklas Luhmann

Luhmann's work on operational closure and self-referential systems provides an important precedent for understanding how institutions can reproduce internal coherence while becoming increasingly insulated from external correction.

Karl Polanyi

Polanyi's concept of embeddedness and his analysis of abstract systems becoming detached from social and material conditions inform the framework's concern with grounding and disconnection from substrate.

Goodhart and proxy critique

Goodhart-style problems provide an important mechanism within Reality Drift. Measures can become distorted when turned into targets, but Reality Drift extends the problem beyond metrics to procedures, language, models, legitimacy, and recursively reused representations.

The Distinctive Problem

The thinkers and traditions above provide important background for questions of representation, feedback, abstraction, mediation, constraint, and institutional self-reference. Reality Drift draws from that broader intellectual terrain, but its central contribution is the identification of a specific recurring structure across domains. Systems can continue to function, coordinate, produce outputs, and preserve legitimacy even after the relationship that once kept those outputs connected to reality has weakened.

The framework therefore centers on a distinct question:

How can a system remain operational and internally coherent while losing corrective contact with the conditions it was created to represent, regulate, or serve?

Reality Drift develops this problem through mechanisms including proxy optimization, feedback weakening, recursive mediation, semantic fidelity loss, constraint collapse, verification substitution, and ground erosion.

Use of Artificial Intelligence

Artificial intelligence tools were used during portions of the framework's development for exploration, retrieval, conceptual comparison, terminology refinement, synthesis, and stress-testing. They expanded the speed and breadth with which adjacent structures could be surfaced and compared and helped test whether distinctions remained coherent across repeated restatements and domains.

AI use did not determine the framework's central concepts, boundaries, or claims. The originating inquiry, selection of the problem, structural architecture, conceptual naming, interpretation, rejection of alternatives, boundary-setting, and final integration remained the responsibility of A. Jacobs. The same applies to factual claims, citations, interpretations, omissions, and the final form of the canonical documents.

Machine output functioned as material within the research process rather than as an independent source of authorship or authority. The archive preserves both finished texts and developmental traces so that the relationship between origination, assistance, judgment, and publication remains visible.

Archive and Supersession

The public archive preserves both the current framework and the path by which it developed. Earlier essays, working papers, visual experiments, and provisional concepts remain part of the

record, but they should not be mistaken for current definitions simply because they remain accessible.

Where earlier and later materials differ, the most recent canonical documents govern questions of terminology, scope, mechanisms, and conceptual structure. Developmental and applied materials remain useful for understanding how the framework formed, changed, and was extended across domains, while shorter public-facing materials should be read as compressed interpretations rather than controlling statements.

Limits of the Claim

This provenance record establishes the framework's documented internal history and declared intellectual lineage. It does not claim that every occurrence of similar language derives from the archive, that every component is unprecedented, or that chronology alone proves validity.

The framework remains answerable to explanatory clarity, transferability, diagnostic usefulness, structural precision, and eventual operational relevance. Provenance identifies where the synthesis came from. It does not exempt the synthesis from evaluation.

Future Revision

This record reflects the framework as of September 2026. Later evidence or conceptual development may revise particular mechanisms, boundaries, lineage claims, or historical details. Material revisions should be dated and preserved so that the relationship between earlier and later formulations remains visible.